

idols from 17 temple sites across India were stolen between 2005 and 2008.

In a major police coup earlier this year, wanted idol smuggling kingpin Sanjive Asokan was arrested for stealing dozens of temple idols and selling them to galleries in the US and Hong Kong for several crores. The illegal smuggling trade, which is part of the largest black economy in the world, is threatening India's rich cultural heritage that dates back to over 4,000 years. While India's legal contemporary art market is pegged at Rs 1,000 crore per year, the illegal market is thought to be worth Rs 500 crore. This thriving trade is organised around a network of criminals, which include local thieves, antique dealers, private collectors as well as corrupt temple guards. And they all are eyeing the lucrative international market. "The number of India-centric galleries is growing in the world. Everybody wants a piece of authentic Indian art, which will increase exploitation," says Amareswar Galla, the founding director of UNESCO's Pacific Asia Observatory of Cultural Diversity in Human Development. There is even a national smuggling museum in Goa showcasing seized art, including 4,000 antique coins.

Ironically, India doesn't even know what treasures exist in the country. It only has records for 3,667 Centrally-

protected monuments. This prompted a Rs 90-crore drive by the ASI in 2007 to start recording every monument and antiquity in India. "A number of important monuments and lakhs of antiquities are still not registered. These should be recorded so there is proof that they exist and the data can be retrieved at the click of a button," says ASI's Superintending Archaeologist for

the Mumbai Circle M.S. Chauhan. Part of the problem stems from lax security. There is a shortage of 10,000 security staff to guard the Centrally-protected monuments. "As against a required 13,230 monument attendants, there are only 3,463," Planning and Parliamentary Affairs Minister V. Narayanasamy recently told Parliament in a written document.

Home to 38,000 temples dating back to the Pallava, Chola and Pandya kingdoms, Tamil Nadu is particularly prone to idol theft. The state has India's only Idol Wing which has recovered 89 metal idols and one emerald lingam worth Rs 63 crore in the past three years. While 65 people have been arrested, only four have been convicted so far. This year, a Rs 50-crore emerald lingam was stolen from a temple and later recovered by the Idol Wing. The state's Idol Wing CID has revealed an elaborate network of accomplices, out to capitalise on the state heritage. Local thieves pass on the stolen items to antique merchants in the guise of art and craft dealers in cities like Chennai, Pondicherry, Kochi and Mahabalipuram, which are then ferried to foreign auction houses and private museums. To dodge customs checks, smugglers take unconventional routes by road and port via Nepal and Myanmar. "The temples provide easy



DEVI WITH HER HUSBAND'S PORTRAIT, WHOSE MEDAL SHE CLAIMS WAS STOLEN

India being a rich hunting ground, many antiquities are finding their way to auction houses abroad



Stolen Item : Antique Idols

Stolen From : Prahadeeswarar Temple and Varadharja Perumal Temple in Tamil Nadu

Found: US and Hong Kong private museums

Status: International idol smuggler Asokan was arrested in 2008 for stealing eight antique and 18 metal idols, worth over Rs 5 crore, between 2006 and 2008. He smuggled the idols out to private galleries in New York and Hong Kong.



Stolen Item : Maraghada Emerald Lingam

Stolen From : Maruntheswarar Temple in Tamil Nadu

Found: In a cylinder buried near thief's home in Thanjavur

Status: A. Ramesh, 30, of Pattukottai and his 29-year-old accomplice P. Senthil of Valangiman were arrested near Chennai in September 2009. They confessed the crime to the police. In February 2009, they had scaled the temple wall and looted a four-inch high emerald lingam, worth Rs 50 crore in the international market. The pair had met in Tiruchi prison in 2008 where they hatched the plot to steal the lingam.